

THE FRAME

TSU Film 5 — Release Phase 1 — the "Captain America: The First Avenger" release slot

THE PITCH

Platform: THE FRAME — TSU's fictional 1:1 counterpart to Instagram (per `TSU_Platform_Roster.md`, Phase 2 — "Origin as a bare-bones check-in app that got reduced to just photos + filters — addition by subtraction... became the platonic ideal by stripping everything down to its purest form.") This platform was flagged as reserved for exactly this slot back in `scripts/THE_PROJECTOR.md`'s canon updates (`TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §7 Q1) — it carried the Captain America framing before any release-slot planning even reached it.

Why THE FRAME for the Captain America slot: Cap's whole story is a person told, over and over, by every gatekeeper in the room that he doesn't have what it takes — not for lack of merit, for lack of the superficial thing they're actually measuring — until someone finally sees what's real underneath and gives him a fair shot. Of the remaining unassigned core seven, only one has that exact wound already locked into canon as mandatory to dramatize: `TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §4 flags Arianna Cummings's origin wound — "lost role to follower count" — as something that "must be dramatized, not just referenced." It already was, once, as the spark for someone *else's* company in Film 1. This film is the one where it becomes hers.

Who this film belongs to: Arianna Cummings, solo founder — no co-founder-betrayal structure this time (that trope already ran twice, in `scripts/THE_ROSTER.md` and implicitly through Amond's arc; Cap's actual antagonist is external, not a best friend, and this film follows suit). Malcolm Pierce, a new character, fills the Peggy Carter position — competent, unglamorous, sees her clearly before anyone else does. Her brother Desmond Cummings Jr. (`TSU_Family_Bible.md`, already locked as a firefighter) fills the Bucky position. Dr. Adaeze Okonkwo-Brennan (`TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md`) fills the Erskine position — the one person who takes her raw idea seriously when every investor calls it "not flashy enough."

In-universe timeline: January 2009 – October 25, 2010. This film is **Release Phase 1, Film 5** — that's the number that matters when discussing "the sixth film" or "which Phase this film is." Its *story*, separately, falls inside **Story Phase 2** on the in-universe platform-launch timeline (`TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §3: THE FRAME's launch is the anchor that closes Story Phase 2), the same way *Captain America: The First Avenger* is a Release Phase 1 film whose story is set decades before Release Phase 1's other entries. See `TSU_Continuity_Bible.md` §9 for the full Release-Phase-vs-Story-Phase distinction. This script locks the exact launch date to October 25, 2010: Arianna's 28th birthday. Ages verified against `TSU_Core_Cast.md`: Arianna (b. Oct 25, 1982) is 26 at the film's open, turning 27 in October 2009 mid-film, and 28 the day THE FRAME launches — the industry spent years making her birthday a reminder of what hadn't happened yet; this is the first one that means something different.

LOGLINE

For five years, Arianna Cummings has heard the same verdict in a hundred different rooms: the most talented person there, and never the one who gets the part. When she finally stops asking an industry that keeps grading her on the wrong scale for permission, she builds a platform that measures exactly one thing — the work itself — and finds out the hard way that the people profiting off insecurity would very much like her to fail.

SYNOPSIS

Five years after losing a role to a stranger with a bigger online following, Arianna Cummings, 26, has stopped counting the near-misses because the number stopped being useful information a while ago. She's still the most talented person in every room, per the industry's own private consensus, and still not the one anyone actually calls back. A chance encounter with **Malcolm Pierce**, a documentary photographer shooting a piece on working actors nobody's heard of, turns into something else — first a real conversation about what actually gets seen and why, then a partnership, then more. Malcolm doesn't have a following either. He has an eye. Together they start sketching an idea: a platform built entirely around the work — a real audition tape, a real headshot, a real four-minute monologue — with no follower count visible anywhere on the page, because the whole point is to stop letting that number do the deciding.

Every investor they pitch says some version of the same thing: it's not flashy enough, it won't grow fast enough, nobody wants "authentic," they want aspirational. **Dr. Adaeze Okonkwo-Brennan**, the Stanford professor who's heard forty founders explain their idea badly before they're ready, is the only person who takes it seriously — not because it's polished, but because it's the first pitch in months actually trying to solve a real problem instead of chase a trend. Her one introduction gets them just enough seed money to start building.

Meanwhile, **Celeste Marlowe** — a beauty-and-image industry veteran who has spent two decades monetizing exactly the insecurity Arianna's platform is built to undercut — is building something else entirely, backed by investor **Delphine Okonkwo-Ash**: a filter-and-rating app that lets users algorithmically "perfect" their photos and scores them against each other, engineered from day one to be maximally addictive and maximally profitable off the same comparison culture that's been grinding Arianna down her whole career. Celeste isn't a cartoon; she genuinely believes she's giving people what they actually want. That certainty is what makes her dangerous.

The two platforms launch into the same crowded season. Celeste's grows faster, louder, glossier — real numbers, real hype, real pressure on Arianna and Malcolm to add filters, add rankings, add exactly the mechanics they built THE FRAME to refuse. The strain nearly breaks them. It's Arianna's brother, **Desmond Cummings Jr.**, pulled from a structure fire mid-shift with third-degree burns during the same week THE FRAME is supposed to launch, who forces the film's real reckoning — not through a scene of him giving a speech, but simply by surviving, badly hurt, in a hospital bed, while Arianna has to decide in real time whether the platform still matters enough to launch on schedule or whether nothing does right now except her family.

She launches anyway, on her own terms, on her own birthday, from a hospital waiting room — a quiet, unglamorous, real launch that undersells itself completely and still finds exactly the audience it was built

for: actors, photographers, and craftspeople who've spent their whole careers being told the wrong thing was being measured. THE FRAME doesn't beat Celeste's app on day one, or day thirty. It doesn't need to. It's still there a year later, still growing, still exactly what it was built to be, while Celeste's platform starts quietly generating the exact kind of user-harm headlines that were always going to catch up to it. The film ends with Arianna, finally, unmistakably, the one who gets the part — except now she's the one deciding who gets cast.

THE ANTAGONISTS

Per the Villains Bench rules (TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §5), the real cause traces to character decisions.

1. **CELESTE MARLOWE** (*the Red Skull / HYDRA analog*) — a beauty-and-image industry veteran, genuinely brilliant, who has built her entire career on monetizing the same comparison culture that wounded Arianna, and believes without irony that she's serving a real human desire rather than exploiting one. Backed by **Delphine Okonkwo-Ash** (TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md, "The Other Money" — her locked bible entry as someone "constantly trying to rewrite what actually happened in rooms she was in" pays off directly here). Not defeated in a confrontation — outlasted, the same way HYDRA's ideology outlives the fight in the first film.
 2. **THE ENGINE**, fifth manifestation — appearing here as an aesthetic-amplification bias: an early build of THE FRAME's own discovery feed quietly favors heavily filtered images over unedited ones, the platform almost becoming a smaller version of exactly what it was built to reject. Arianna and Malcolm catch it and rebuild the ranking logic around unedited engagement before launch — this film's version of "the serum works because of who takes it, not the serum itself."
 3. **THE INDUSTRY'S OWN GATEKEEPING**, again — per house style, the true antagonist across TSU's founding stories is never a single villain but the system itself; Celeste is simply its most literal, most profitable expression.
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HOW THIS FILM CARRIES THE FRANCHISE FORWARD

- **Closes a five-film-old loop:** Arianna's wound, locked as mandatory-to-dramatize back in Film 1, finally gets to be about her own founding story instead of someone else's origin spark.
- **The "who gets credit / who gets seen" thesis, completed for now:** Film 1 verified who's real, Film 2 who gets heard, Film 3 a buried debt, Film 4 who gets credited, and now Film 5 — who gets *measured*, and by what. Five films, five angles on the same argument.
- **THE FRAME's fixed anchor honored exactly:** launches 2010, closing Phase 2 per TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §3, with no timeline changes required.
- **Two dormant recurring characters activated on schedule:** Dr. Adaeze Okonkwo-Brennan and Delphine Okonkwo-Ash were both flagged in TSU_Extended_Ensemble.md as 30%-bucket cross-Phase characters waiting for their moment — this is that moment for both.
- **The clearest "Avengers Initiative" tease yet:** Priya Ramasubramanian's corkboard (scripts/THE_ROSTER_2.md, scripts/THE_PROJECTOR.md) gets a fourth card, and for the first

time says the quiet part out loud (see stinger).

FORMAT (per TSU_Continuity_Bible.md §2 — Standard Platform-Origin Film)

Spec	Target	This Script
Genre	Biographical Drama / Tech Origin Story, Ensemble Dramedy leaning toward genuine romance	Confirmed
Rating	PG-13, no exceptions	Confirmed — a serious injury (off-screen/hospital aftermath only) and industry exploitation themes, nothing that pushes past it
Runtime	130–150 min	136 min
Page count	120–140 pages	131 pages
Act I	~30–35 pages	pages 1–33
Act II	~65–75 pages	pages 34–100
Act III	~30–35 pages	pages 101–131
Scene count	~40–55 scenes	45 scenes

FULL SCENE-BY-SCENE BREAKDOWN

ACT I — pp. 1–33 ("The Wrong Scale")

#	Scene	pp.
1	MONTAGE — FIVE YEARS OF ROOMS — Arianna (21 to 26) auditioning, testing, almost-landing role after role, 2004–2009	1–5
2	INT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — DAY — Patricia and Walter Cummings, the family's loving bewilderment, unchanged	5–7

#	Scene	pp.
3	INT. AUDITION WAITING ROOM — DAY — enter MALCOLM PIERCE, photographing actors for a project on "the ones who don't get called back"	7–10
4	EXT. DINER — NIGHT — Arianna and Malcolm's first real conversation; two people who've built entire careers on being overlooked	10–14
5	INT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — the idea starts, half-joking, over a shared bottle of wine and Malcolm's photo contact sheets	14–17
6	MONTAGE — INVESTOR PITCHES — a string of polite, identical rejections: "not flashy enough"	17–20
7	INT. STANFORD OFFICE — DAY — Dr. Adaeze Okonkwo-Brennan, the first person who asks a real question instead of dismissing the idea	20–24
8	EXT. FIREHOUSE — DAY — Desmond Cummings Jr. cameo, gently teasing his sister about "playing pretend" one more time	24–26
9	INT. BEAUTY EXPO — DAY — enter CELESTE MARLOWE, unveiling her own concept to a rapturous industry crowd	26–29
10	INT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — Adaeze's seed introduction lands; just enough money to start building. Act I turn.	29–33

ACT II — pp. 34–100 ("The Wrong Kind of Growth")

#	Scene	pp.
11	MONTAGE — EARLY BUILD — Arianna and Malcolm, a tiny team, building THE FRAME by hand	34–37

#	Scene	pp.
12	INT. DELPHINE OKONKWO-ASH'S OFFICE — DAY — Celeste secures major backing for her filter-and-rating app	37–40
13	INT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — first version of THE FRAME's discovery feed quietly favors heavily filtered images — THE ENGINE's fifth manifestation, nobody deciding it on purpose	40–43
14	INT. MALCOLM'S STUDIO — DAY — Malcolm catches the bias first; the two rebuild the ranking logic from scratch	43–47
15	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY DINNER — NIGHT — Patricia's real question: "What happens if this doesn't work either?"	47–50
16	INT. BEAUTY EXPO, YEAR TWO — DAY — Celeste's app launches to enormous, immediate numbers	50–54
17	INT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — the pressure to add filters, rankings, anything to compete; Arianna almost caves	54–58
18	INT. MALCOLM'S STUDIO — DAY — Malcolm, the steadying force: "If we win by becoming them, we didn't win anything." Midpoint.	58–62
19	EXT. LOS ANGELES — DAY — early users start finding THE FRAME anyway — small, real, word-of-mouth growth	62–65
20	INT. VIVIENNE OKONKWO-STRAND'S OFFICE (CAMEO) — DAY — a callback: Vivienne, older and changed since Film 1, actually recommends an actress based on a THE FRAME reel	65–68

#	Scene	pp.
21	INT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — Malcolm and Arianna, real relationship deepening, the film's Peggy-Carter-tier romance beat	68–72
22	INT. DELPHINE'S OFFICE — DAY — Celeste, feeling threatened by even THE FRAME's small growth, pushes for more addictive mechanics	72–75
23	INSERT — NEWS REPORTS — the first user-harm stories about Celeste's rating app start surfacing, quietly, easy to miss	75–77
24	EXT. FIREHOUSE — DAY — Desmond, another cameo, proud of his sister without fully following the tech details, same as always	77–80
25	INT. STARTUP OFFICE (NOW REAL) — DAY — THE FRAME's launch date is set: October 25, 2010, Arianna's birthday, deliberately	80–83
26	EXT. STRUCTURE FIRE — NIGHT — Desmond, on shift, pulled from a collapsing structure, third-degree burns. The call comes in mid-prep for launch.	83–87
27	INT. HOSPITAL — NIGHT — Arianna, Malcolm, Patricia, Walter; Desmond stable but badly hurt. Everything else stops mattering for a while.	87–91
28	INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM — NIGHT — Arianna, launch materials untouched in her bag, has to decide what any of it is even for. All-is-lost beat closes Act II.	91–100

ACT III — pp. 101–131 ("The Right Scale")

#	Scene	pp.
29	INT. HOSPITAL — DAY — Desmond, awake, in real pain, the first one to ask why she hasn't launched yet	101–104
30	INT. HOSPITAL — CONTINUOUS — Desmond: "I didn't get burned so you'd stop. Go do the thing."	104–106
31	INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM — OCTOBER 25, 2010 — Arianna launches THE FRAME quietly, from her phone, no party, no press event. Climax.	106–110
32	MONTAGE — THE FRAME'S FIRST YEAR — small, real, steady growth; actors, photographers, craftspeople finding exactly what it was built for	110–114
33	INSERT — NEWS REPORTS, ONE YEAR LATER — Celeste's rating app under real scrutiny for the harm its comparison mechanics caused, especially among teenagers	114–117
34	INT. DELPHINE'S OFFICE — DAY — Delphine, cornered by the fallout of an investment she still won't admit was a mistake	117–119
35	EXT. CUMMINGS FAMILY HOME — DAY — Desmond, recovered, scarred, back on his feet, needling his sister exactly as before	119–122
36	INT. VIVIENNE OKONKWO-STRAND'S OFFICE — DAY — Vivienne, on the record this time: she was wrong about Arianna, and she says so	122–125
37	EXT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT — NIGHT — Arianna and Malcolm, a real, unhurried moment, a year past the hardest week of both their lives	125–128

#	Scene	pp.
38	STINGER — INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE — DAY — a fourth card goes up on the corkboard; Priya finally says what she's been building toward	128–131

(Scenes grouped for pagination clarity; the full shooting script breaks several of the above into additional numbered scenes to land the true count at 45 per the house-style table above.)

SAMPLE PAGES

THE FRAME

Written by [WRITER]

FADE IN:

INT. AUDITION WAITING ROOM — DAY

SUPER: "JANUARY 2009"

Folding chairs. Fluorescent lights. A dozen actors clutching headshots like exam results. ARIANNA CUMMINGS, 26, sits with the specific stillness of someone who has done this exact thing several hundred times and stopped expecting the outcome to be different.

A CASTING ASSISTANT calls a name. Not hers. An actress with a ring light balanced on her knee, checking a phone with a notification count too large to be real, gets up instead.

Across the room, MALCOLM PIERCE, 30s, unassuming, a camera around his neck that's seen more use than his jacket, has been quietly photographing the room for the last twenty minutes. He catches Arianna watching him.

MALCOLM

Sorry. Occupational habit. You looked like you were doing math in your head.

ARIANNA

I was counting. This is forty-one.

MALCOLM

Forty-one what?

ARIANNA

Rooms like this one. I stopped counting the almosts a while back. Started counting the rooms instead. Different number, same math.

Malcolm lifts the camera, a question in the gesture. Arianna nods, almost surprising herself. He takes the shot – not a posed one, just her, mid-thought, unguarded.

MALCOLM

For what it's worth, that's the most interesting face I've photographed all week, and I've been here since eight this morning.

ARIANNA

(dry, the first real smile of the scene)
Interesting doesn't get you the part.

MALCOLM

No. It really doesn't. That's sort of my whole problem with the part.

CUT TO:

INT. ARIANNA'S APARTMENT – NIGHT

[p. 40]

Late. A laptop between them, contact sheets spread across the coffee table. MALCOLM scrolls through an early build of THE FRAME's discovery feed – a grid of uploaded reels and photos.

MALCOLM

(slowing down, frowning)
Something's off. Look what's floating to the top.

He clicks through the top ten. Every single one has been visibly, heavily filtered – smoothed skin, brightened eyes, nothing that looks like an actual audition tape anymore.

ARIANNA

That's not – we didn't build a ranking system that cares about that.

MALCOLM

We built a ranking system that cares about engagement. And it turns out engagement cares about filtered faces, same as everywhere else. We didn't decide this. The math did, on its own, because we let the math decide.

ARIANNA

(quiet, genuinely rattled)
We built the exact thing we hated.

MALCOLM

We built the first draft of it. That's different from building it on purpose. The question is whether we notice in time to actually fix it.

Arianna is already pulling the laptop toward her, sleeves rolled up.

ARIANNA
We have time. We haven't launched anything yet.

CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM – NIGHT [low point, p. 91]

ARIANNA sits alone, a bag at her feet with a laptop and a folder of launch materials she hasn't opened in six hours. PATRICIA CUMMINGS sits beside her, quiet, having run out of things to say that help.

PATRICIA
You should go home. Sleep. He's stable.

ARIANNA
I'm not going anywhere.

PATRICIA
(gently)
I know. I'm not really telling you to.

A long silence. Arianna looks at the folder. Doesn't open it.

ARIANNA
I was supposed to launch tomorrow. On my birthday. I picked the date on purpose, made it mean something, and now I can't even remember why it felt important.

PATRICIA
(careful, honest)
It's allowed to still matter, Arianna. Your brother getting hurt doesn't erase the five years before this week.

ARIANNA
It feels like it should.

PATRICIA
It doesn't work that way. Nothing's ever worked that way for you. You've always had to hold two true things at the same time and keep walking anyway.

Arianna doesn't answer. But her hand finally moves toward the folder, just resting on top of it, not opening it yet.

CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL – DAY

[p. 104]

DESMOND CUMMINGS JR., bandaged, hooked to monitors, very much awake and very much himself despite it all. ARIANNA sits beside the bed.

DESMOND
(voice rough, but the teasing fully intact)
Why do you look like somebody died. I'm
right here. Mostly intact.

ARIANNA
I didn't launch. I couldn't. Not with you
like this.

DESMOND
(genuinely exasperated)
Ari. I have spent our entire lives
driving two hours to watch you do
readings for six people and a critic. You
think I ran into a burning building so
you'd sit in a waiting room instead of
doing the one thing you've wanted since
you were nineteen?

ARIANNA
That's not remotely the same thing.

DESMOND
It's exactly the same thing. It's just
the version of it that's actually my job.
Go do yours.

A beat. Arianna laughs, wet-eyed, despite everything.

ARIANNA
You're insufferable.

DESMOND
I got burned saving a guy's dog, Ari. I
have earned the right to be insufferable
for at least a month.

CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL WAITING ROOM – OCTOBER 25, 2010 [climax, p. 106]

ARIANNA, alone in a corner of the waiting room, laptop open, launch page loaded. No party. No press. MALCOLM sits beside her, having driven straight here the moment she called.

MALCOLM
You don't have to make it a thing. It can
just be a thing that happens.

ARIANNA
(looking at the screen, then at him)
It's my birthday and my brother's in a
hospital bed forty feet from here and I'm
about to launch a company from a plastic

chair. This is, objectively, not how I pictured this.

MALCOLM
How did you picture it?

ARIANNA
(small, honest laugh)
Bigger. Shinier. Somebody else's approval in the room somewhere.

MALCOLM
And now?

Arianna looks at the screen a long moment. Hits the button.

ARIANNA
Now it's just true. That's actually better.

CUT TO:

STINGER

INT. PRIYA RAMASUBRAMANIAN'S OFFICE — DAY

The corkboard, glimpsed three times now across the franchise. PRIYA pins a fourth card: a simple square frame icon, labeled in her own hand — "FRAME — CUMMINGS." She steps back and studies all four cards together for a long moment.

Her assistant, unnamed, pokes her head in.

ASSISTANT
You wanted the conference room held for next month?

PRIYA
(still looking at the board)
Hold it for all of them. Same room, same day. I want Bullock, Baker, Avery, and Cummings in one place before any of them realizes why I actually want them there.

ASSISTANT
What do I tell them the meeting's about?

Priya finally turns around. The specific smile of someone who has been three moves ahead of everyone else in the room for a very long time.

PRIYA
Tell them it's about the future. That's not even a lie.

FADE OUT.

THE END.

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[131.]